



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Literature



Your notes

How to Answer the Paper 2 Drama Questions

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Question A: What The Question Is Asking



Your notes

Question A: What The Question Is Asking

Question A of Paper 2: Drama is the **passage-based question**. You must ensure you select the correct page of the exam paper that relates to the set text you have studied. The guide below will enable you to approach Question A with confidence. It is divided into:

- Overview
- Breaking down the question
- Top tips

Overview

You should answer one passage-based question on one set text, and one essay question on another set text. Question A will give you a passage from the drama text printed on the exam paper. This Question is worth 25 marks and assesses all four Assessment Objectives. You have 45 minutes to answer this question.

In your response you are expected to:

- Demonstrate your knowledge of the play through reference to detail and the use of accurate, relevant quotations from the text
- Show that you understand the main ideas and explicit meanings in the play, as well as the implied or hidden meanings
- Analyse, in detail, the choices the writer has made in terms of their use of language, structure and form to **convey** impressions and ideas
- Shape your writing in such a way as to communicate your engagement with the play
- Demonstrate your understanding of the play, and the question
- Be sensitive to imagery, sound and language to develop an informed personal response to the play

The suggested timings for the Question A passage-based question are:

10 minutes	▪ Highlight the key words in the question ▪ Read the passage ▪ Annotate in the margins ▪ Make a brief plan of the structure of your answer
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30 minutes	- Follow your plan or annotations - Write your response
5 minutes	Re-read and check your response



Your notes

It is important to read and check your work, rather than to try to write as much as you can in the time allowed. Answers that are shorter, but more focused and **concise**, are often more successful.

Breaking down the question

For this question, you will always be asked to write a response that explores how a writer conveys their meanings and message in their play, focusing on a specific aspect or theme. The most common mistake students make in exams is not thoroughly understanding the question. By paying close attention to the question and understanding it thoroughly, you can enhance your exam performance significantly.

Below are a range of examples of Paper 2 Question A passage-based questions taken from past CIE IGCSE papers:

The focus of each question is indicated in bold

Explore the **ways** in which Miller makes this such a **dramatic and significant moment** in the play.

In what **ways** does Priestley make this moment in the play so **dramatic and revealing**?

How does Shakespeare make this such a **powerful and memorable moment** in the play?

How does Wilde make this moment in the play so **entertaining**?

How does Miller **vividly portray Reverend Parris** at this **early moment** in the play?

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Top tips

- Highlight the key words in the question:
 - The most successful answers maintain a clear focus on the key words in the question
 - Therefore, pay particular attention to what the question is asking you to do
 - Then, as you read through the passage, highlight and annotate key words and phrases directly relevant to the focus of the question
- Quotations are intended to support your points, but should not be a point in themselves:
 - The strongest answers show a detailed knowledge of the text, by integrating precise and concise quotations and indirect textual references to support points



- You need to be able to analyse and explain the relevance of the quotations you have chosen to your argument or to the question you are answering
- You should structure your response and your use of quotations in chronological order, and ensure that you respond to every section of the passage:
 - You should aim to select 6–7 relevant quotations that contain a range of language and/or structure devices that you can comment upon and analyse
 - A high-level response will incorporate these quotations into the explanations of meaning
- Do not just state your ideas:
 - The most convincing responses sustain a critical engagement with the ways in which writers achieve their effects
 - Therefore, it is important that your explanation and analysis is supported with reasons
 - Use words such as “because”, “as” or “since” to offer reasons as to how the writer’s choices of language and structure achieve the particular effects that you mention
 - Make sure you link all of your ideas and reasons to the question
- Embed your quotations into your sentences:
 - Avoid unnecessary phrases such as “This is shown by the quote...” as this is just a waste of words
 - Instead, try: “Shakespeare makes this moment in the play so upsetting because Balthasar reveals that ‘her body sleeps in Capels’ monument’, which leads to the ultimate tragedy in the play”
- Ensure your introduction demonstrates that you have understood the task and that you have a thorough knowledge of the play:
 - You can do this by defining the focus of the question and summarising the main themes of the play
- Do not waste words on general topic sentences that do not make a specific point:
 - For example: “The passage is upsetting because of the language Shakespeare uses.”
 - This does not make any specific point that the examiner could reward with a mark
- Avoid being narrative:
 - You do not get any marks for just re-telling the story of the play
- Make sure every paragraph answers the question:
 - Do not just write down everything you know about the play without any focus on the question
 - Make every sentence count!



Your notes

- Ensure you include analysis of the use of structure and the form of the play, as well as dramatic techniques:
 - Writing just about the writer's use of language can limit your marks
- In addition, avoid "feature-spotting":
 - Listing techniques a writer has used without analysis will not get you marks
- Your conclusion should be relevant and should summarise your personal response to the play and the task:
 - The strongest answers provide evidence of an informed and sensitive personal response to the text, which focuses directly on the key words of the question
 - It should not just repeat points you have already made
- Avoid lengthy discussion of the historical context of the writer and/or the time in which the play was written:
 - Context is not explicitly assessed in this IGCSE
 - Instead, your wider background knowledge should be used to inform your personal response to the play



Question A: How To Get Full Marks

The starting point for the analysis of any text is active reading. This means, as you read, annotating the text with your own comments and questions. Plays will often contain many layers of meaning, so it is important that you explore beyond any surface meanings to uncover the deeper ideas and themes. Some appreciation of the context in which a play was written can also help your understanding, but this should never be the main focus of your exploration.

It is tempting to jump straight in and start writing immediately. However, following this guide will ensure you answer the question in the way the examiners are looking for.

Below you will find sections on:

- What skills are required
- Steps for success
- Top tips

What skills are required

Each question on this exam paper assesses all four Assessment Objectives equally. This means it is important that you know what skills these Assessment Objectives require you to demonstrate in order to get the most marks.

- **AO1** is about demonstrating knowledge of the play's content through reference to specific sections of the text:
 - As you read through the passage, **annotate** any questions you have
 - This objective is about working out what is going on in terms of content, structure and word choice
- **AO2** is about going beyond the surface meaning and story, to look for underlying ideas and attitudes – the writer's and your own:
 - This requires you to ask "why" the author has made the choices they have
 - Some elements of the writer's context can be used to inform your personal response, but only if relevant to the focus of the question
- **AO3** requires **critical engagement** and evaluation of how the text works:
 - "Meanings and effects" suggests that there is more than one meaning for a text, and the language, structure and form of the play contribute to those meanings
 - It does not mean just listing the literary techniques the writer has used
- **AO4** refers to the way you shape your writing in order to communicate your engagement with the text:



- A personal response means that you may wish to make comparisons with similar experiences of your own, whether in real life or in your reading
- Contextual information should help reinforce your own interpretation, but not replace it
- Your own response is valid as long as it is supported by evidence

The following sections explore the skills you will need to demonstrate in more detail:

- Analysing drama
- Developing a personal response

Analysing drama

It is essential to remember that drama is written for an audience; plays and drama texts are intended for performance on a stage. This impacts how you read and consider a dramatic text, as you also need to consider how a play would appear to an audience.

Form and structure apply to drama as well as poetry and prose. The form is the type of writing the author has selected to tell their story and explore themes when presenting their work, while the structure is how the piece of drama unfolds. It is therefore important to consider what choices the writer has made in terms of form and structure, and whether they have conformed to, or subverted, the conventions of that particular form or elements of structure. The examples below are not exhaustive, and you are encouraged to research the dramatic form of your set texts.

Dramatic form	Definition	Example
Farce	Comedy that entertains through situations that are highly exaggerated, extravagant, ridiculous or absurd	The Comedy of Errors by William Shakespeare
Satire	A play written to criticise people or situations in a humorous or ironic way	Animal Farm by George Orwell
Melodrama	A play involving strong or exaggerated events and emotions	Still Life, Brief Encounter by Noel Coward
Domestic drama	A play that focuses on the realistic everyday lives of the middle or lower classes in a certain society	Death of a Salesman by Arthur Miller
Heroic drama	A play that involves epic stories of noble heroes and lavish, exotic settings	The Indian Queen by Robert Howard
Historical drama	Dramatic texts based on historical material	Henry V by William Shakespeare



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners like to see that students have an awareness of the form of a text, whether it's a novel, a play, a poem, etc. All texts on this paper are **plays**, and so it's important that you signal to the examiner that you know this. This is as simple as using the term "**audience**" instead of **reader**, and other play-specific terminology such as "**act**", "**scene**", "**on stage**" and even "**playwright**" instead of writer.

It is also important to add that commenting on stage directions is as valuable as analysing any other writer's method. Indeed, it has the advantage of showing the examiner you are aware of the writer's intentions (the overall message he/she is trying to convey), because all stage directions are literally their intentions for what happens on stage.



Your notes

Dramatic structure	Explanation
Plot structure	A plot could be cyclical: ▪ This means there could be a recurrent theme or motif Or it could mean that the plot "circles back" to the beginning The writer might also use parallelism: ▪ This means the use of matching sentences or phrases to balance ideas of equal importance You might also wish to consider the arrangements of scenes and/or acts, and why the writer has positioned them in the way that they have
Mood	Mood describes the feelings or attitudes of roles and/or characters It is the emotional impact intended by the writer
Juxtaposition	To place two things side by side to compare or contrast for effect: ▪ This might include the use of foil characters ▪ A foil is a character who contrasts with another character ▪ For example, Harry Potter and Voldemort are foils
Foreshadowing	This is a warning or a prediction of a future event in the play The writer might also employ dramatic irony, where the audience might be aware of what is coming, but the characters are not



Your notes

In medias res	This is when the play starts in the middle of the action
Flashbacks	A scene in a play set in a time earlier than the main story: ■ This device can be used to convey extra information about plot or character
Soliloquies/dialogue	A soliloquy is a speech that a character makes to themselves: ■ It is a device through which a character's inner thoughts can be made known to the audience Dialogue is a conversation between two or more characters in a play

You might also wish to consider the use of stage directions, setting, how conflicts are introduced and resolved (or not) and character development, and it is always a good idea to take particular note of how the play ends.

Some of the other things you need to consider when preparing your answer to the passage-based question include:

Where does the passage occur in the play as a whole?	■ Locate where the passage is located in the scene and/or play ■ What events have occurred? What might the characters be reacting to, or affected by? ■ Where is the passage going to lead? ■ Identify who is speaking, to whom, and who else might be present ■ What prominent themes of the play are developed in the passage and how are they advanced or deepened? ■ Why does this conversation and/or action take place? ■ Why did the writer include this scene, with these characters, in this location?
What choices has the writer made in terms of language, form and structure?	■ Is action taking place, or is it being conveyed indirectly e.g. through descriptive speech? ■ What effect does this passage have on the audience? ■ Is the passage in verse or in prose? ■ Is punctuation abundant or sparse? How do these details betray the mood of the characters or of the scene?



Your notes

	■ Look at language – dialects, lexis, tone – how does this affect mood? Is there anything particularly significant about what is said and how it is said? ■ Explore any use of imagery – why did the writer use this metaphor/simile etc.? ■ Consider how genre is manipulated or referred to in the scene. Does it use traditional or comedic forms? How are they imitated or distorted by the writer?
How is the play staged?	■ The level of detail a writer provides in their scripts is called staging ■ A playwright cannot rely on descriptions, so everything they want their audience to be aware of has to be seen or heard on stage ■ So, ask yourself what the writer tells you about setting, lighting, sound or props ■ If the writer has given very detailed staging instructions, why have they done this? What does this tell you?
How are stage directions used?	■ These might include instructions on how an actor should deliver a particular line ■ The level of detail may vary, so again consider why the writer has included stage directions



Examiner Tips and Tricks

If you are studying a Shakespeare play as one of your set texts, then you might find our AQA revision notes on [How to Answer the Shakespeare Essay Question](#) helpful, as these go into detail about the different forms of Shakespearean drama and how to quote from Shakespearean plays.

Developing a personal response

A personal response is your opinion about the text, as relevant to the focus of the question. You are being asked to consider what the writer has tried to do and whether you think they have succeeded. However, it is important that your arguments are convincing, which means that they need to be supported with evidence. Your choice of evidence, whether that be direct quotation of language, or references to the form and structure of a text, must be careful, accurate and effectively explained.

How to structure your response:



Your notes

Start with an introduction that demonstrates that you understand the focus of the question and the play	■ You can do this by using the wording of the question to develop a thesis statement ■ For example: "Shakespeare makes this moment in the play so upsetting because it happens when..."
Then, structure your response into paragraphs	■ Each paragraph should start with a topic sentence ■ You should integrate direct quotation or specific reference to the text to prove your point ■ Then comment on how this evidence proves your point ■ Each point you make must be directly relevant to the focus of the question
With the passage-based question:	■ Start with a close analysis of the passage, linking to the focus of the question ■ Then, incorporate commentary on how the extract relates to the text as a whole ■ Think of the passage as a stepping stone to the whole text
Finish with a conclusion	■ Summarise your findings and your response to these findings ■ Do not just repeat the points you have already made

Steps for success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering the passage-based drama question effectively:

1. Grab your highlighter and **read the question first**:

- Read carefully and highlight the focus of the question

2. Read the passage with the focus of the question in mind:

- Highlight and annotate as you read
- Note down any comments about structure, form and language that will help you to answer the question



Your notes

- Ask yourself: how does what I am noting down show the focus of the question?

- Do not just write a list of techniques the writer has used

3. Do a brief plan of 4–5 points, linking to the quotations you are going to use

4. Start your answer using the wording of the question:

- This demonstrates to the examiner that you have understood both the question, the passage and the play

5. Go into detail:

- Now you need to make as many points as possible, ranging throughout the passage and play
- It is a good idea to make your points in chronological order, if possible
- Use the annotations you have made in the margins to form the basis of each point:
 - Make your point, then support it with quotations and/or direct references to the passage
 - Explain how the quote highlights the idea in the question
 - Analyse what the key words and phrases in the quote make the reader feel about the idea in the question
- Comment on and analyse language, form and structure
- Link your ideas to the theme and the focus of the question:
 - You should refer back to the keyword in the question throughout your answer
 - Use “because” or “as” to support your ideas with detailed reasons
- Explore the writer’s intention and message

6. Sum up:

- Finish your answer with a “So overall...” statement
- Zoom back out to the big ideas in the text
- Your finishing statement should sum up what you have discovered, relevant to the focus of the question:
 - However, it should not just repeat the points you have already made

Top tips

- Avoid being too general or vague in your introduction:
 - Your introduction should address the Assessment Objectives in some way
- Avoid simply “re-telling” the narrative of the play
- Make sure every paragraph answers the question:
 - Do not just write everything you know about the text

- Avoid unnecessary words
- Re-read each of the paragraphs you have written before you write the next:
 - Check that each paragraph is clear and that it answers the question
- Ensure your selection of quotations is directly relevant to the focus of the question



Your notes



Question A: Mark Scheme and Model Answer

The best way to improve any essay is to know how you are assessed, and what skills you are being assessed on. This page has been created to give you a sense of what examiners are looking for in a full-mark response. It contains:

- Overview
- Mark scheme
- Example task
- Model answer
- Unannotated model answer

Overview

Question A (the passage-based question) will give you a passage from the drama text printed on the exam paper, and you will be asked to analyse how the writer has achieved particular meanings or ideas. Your response must be supported with direct quotations or close reference to the passage and the rest of the play.

Mark scheme

The mark scheme for any question in Literature in English is quite broad and can seem difficult to understand. This is because there is no “correct answer” for any essay: the exam board does not provide points that need to be included in any essay; instead, examiners use the mark scheme to place an answer into a level.

The questions in Paper 2 are equally weighted, and each question tests all four Assessment Objectives.

In simple terms, to achieve the highest marks (Band 8 = 23–25 marks), this means:

AO1	▪ Demonstrate your knowledge by incorporating well-selected reference to the text skillfully and with flair in your answers ▪ This means using quotations and indirect references to the play to support your views or arguments
AO2	▪ Sustain a critical understanding of the text by showing individuality and insight ▪ This means showing that you understand the main ideas, settings, events, characters and other dramatic features, and that you appreciate the deeper meanings of the play



Your notes

AO3	- Respond sensitively and in considerable detail to the way the writer achieves her/his effects - This means that you are able to explore how writers use language, structure and form to convey impressions and ideas
AO4	- Sustain a personal and evaluative engagement with the task and text - This means that you are able to give a personal response to the question and text, and support your response with references to the text



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although there are four specific Assessment Objectives assessed in this task, it is not the case that a certain number of marks are awarded for any one objective. Instead, the examiners are looking for a well-constructed and coherent essay that seamlessly combines all of the skills covered by the Assessment Objectives.

Example task

The following task is taken from the CIE IGCSE 2017 Paper 2, and is about An Inspector Calls by JB Priestley. It is typical of the style of a Paper 2 Question A passage-based question:

Read this passage carefully, and then answer the question that follows it:

<i>Birling:</i>	Giving us the port, Edna? That's right. [<i>he pushes it towards ERIC.</i>] You ought to like this port, Gerald. As a matter of fact, Finchley told me it's exactly the same port your father gets from him.	
<i>Gerald:</i>	Then it'll be all right. The governor prides himself on being a good judge of port. I don't pretend to know much about it.	5
<i>Sheila</i>	[<i>gaily, possessively</i>]: I should jolly well think not, Gerald, I'd hate you to know all about port – like one of these purple-faced old men.	
<i>Birling:</i>	Here, I'm not a purple-faced old man.	
<i>Sheila:</i>	No, not yet. But then you don't know all about port – do you?	
<i>Birling</i>	[<i>noticing that his wife has not taken any</i>]: Now then, Sybil, you must take a little tonight. Special occasion, y'know, eh?	10
<i>Sheila:</i>	Yes, go on, mummy. You must drink our health.	
<i>Mrs Birling</i>	[<i>smiling</i>]: Very well, then. Just a little, thank you. [<i>to EDNA, who is about to go, with tray</i>]: All right, Edna. I'll ring from the drawing room when we want coffee. Probably in about half an hour.	15
<i>Edna</i>	[<i>going</i>]: Yes, ma'am. [<i>EDNA goes out. They now have all the glasses filled. BIRLING beams at them and clearly relaxes.</i>]	
<i>Birling:</i>	Well, well – this is very nice. Very nice. Good dinner too, Sybil. Tell cook from me.	
<i>Gerald</i>	[<i>politely</i>]: Absolutely first-class.	20



Your notes

Mrs Birling	[reproachfully]: Arthur, you're not supposed to say such things —	
Birling:	Oh — come, come — I'm treating Gerald like one of the family. And I'm sure he won't object.	
Sheila	[with mocking aggressiveness]: Go on, Gerald — just you object!	
Gerald	[smiling]: Wouldn't dream of it. In fact, I insist upon being one of the family now. I've been trying long enough, haven't I? [as she does not reply, with more insistence] Haven't I? You know I have.	25
Mrs Birling	[smiling]: Of course she does.	
Sheila	[half serious, half playful]: Yes — except for all last summer, when you never came near me, and I wondered what had happened to you.	30
Gerald:	And I've told you — I was awfully busy at the works all that time.	
Sheila	[same tone as before]: Yes, that's what you say.	
Mrs Birling:	Now, Sheila, don't tease him. When you're married you'll realize that men with important work to do sometimes have to spend nearly all their time and energy on their business. You'll have to get used to that, just as I had.	35
Sheila:	I don't believe I will. [Half playful, half serious, to GERALD.] So you be careful.	
Gerald:	Oh — I will, I will. [ERIC suddenly guffaws. His parents look at him.]	
Sheila	[severely]: Now — what's the joke?	
Eric:	I don't know — really. Suddenly I felt I just had to laugh.	40
Sheila:	You're squiffy.	
Eric:	I'm not.	
Mrs Birling:	What an expression, Sheila! Really the things you girls pick up these days!	
Eric:	If you think that's the best she can do —	
Sheila:	Don't be an ass, Eric.	45
Mrs Birling:	Now stop it, you two. Arthur, what about this famous toast of yours?	
Birling:	Yes, of course. [Clears his throat.] Well, Gerald, I know you agreed that we should only have this quiet little family party. It's a pity Sir George and — er — Lady Croft can't be with us, but they're abroad and so it can't be helped. As I told you, they sent me a very nice cable — couldn't be nicer. I'm not sorry that we're celebrating quietly like this —	50
Mrs Birling:	Much nicer really.	
Gerald:	I agree.	
Birling:	So do I, but it makes speech-making more difficult —	
Eric	[not too rudely]: Well, don't do any. We'll drink their health and have done with it.	55

[From Act 1]

How does Priestley make this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft?

Model Answer

Below you will find a full-mark model answer for this task. The commentary labelled in each section of the essay illustrates how and why it would be awarded full marks. Despite the fact it is an answer to the above question on *An Inspector Calls*, the commentary is relevant to any of the plays in the set text list, because it is modelling how to structure an answer incorporating the relevant Assessment Objectives.



The introduction shows a clear focus of the key word in the question – “striking” – and demonstrates thorough knowledge of the play

Priestley makes this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft by beginning the play in medias res at the Birling residence. Arthur Birling leads a toast to the upcoming marriage of his daughter, Sheila, and his future son-in-law, Gerald, and the audience learns that Gerald was occupied the previous summer at “the works”. It is later revealed that this is a manufacturing company owned by his father and that it is a direct competitor to Birling and Company, Arthur’s business. There appears to be an undercurrent of unease, revealed via Priestley’s use of forced and stunted dialogue and stage directions.

It also acknowledges the fact that it is the writer’s methods that create a striking introduction to the characters

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Shows a clear understanding of how Sheila feels, with well-chosen evidence supporting the point

Firstly, Priestley employs the use of tone, as Sheila urges Gerald with “mocking aggressiveness” to “object” to being treated like one of the family. She continues, with the stage directions indicating a half serious, half playful tone, reproaching Gerald that he “never came near me” all the previous summer. Gerald’s excuse was that he was “awfully busy at the works” and she responds in the same tone “that’s what you say”. This foreshadows the revelation of Gerald’s affair, and the “half serious, half playful” stage direction could reflect her naivety at the start of the play versus her maturity at the end. The audience is forewarned here that all might not be well, and the fact that Sheila is taking her first, tentative steps towards asserting her sense of self and rejecting a typical patriarchal marriage reflects the new, emerging role of women at the time Priestley wrote the play. Traditional patriarchal attitudes towards the role of women, especially in marriage, are reinforced by Mrs Birling when she tells Sheila that she will just have to get used to her husband not being around due to “work”. This is ironic and perpetuates the idea that such indiscretions can be overlooked as men are busy with important matters of business, and that their wives should be grateful.

Again, this demonstrates knowledge of the play as a whole and how this passage fits within the context of the play

This shows good understanding of the play and a personal engagement with the themes

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Remains focused on the question while incorporating a different personal response

Furthermore, the introduction to the Birling family is striking in the absence of Gerald's parents at an engagement party. The use of the noble titles "Sir George" and "Lady Croft" suggest that there is a disparity in class between the Crofts and the Birlings, and that the marriage might not be as accepted by Gerald's parents if Sheila is seen to be of lower social standing. Mr Birling's sexist attitudes are reinforced by the hesitation in remembering Lady Croft's title, as indicated by the dash and the interjection "er". It is also striking that Mr Birling struggles to remember the name of one of his future son-in-law's parents, betraying his arrogance and ignorance. This is especially striking given that Mr Birling is clearly trying to impress Gerald, as he is keen to point out that the port he is serving is "exactly the same port your father gets". Mr Birling is clearly disappointed at the Croft family's absence, as it upsets his moment in the spotlight as the father of the bride, and the opportunity to show off his wealth ostentatiously. His attitude and symbols of status, such as the port, would have immediately introduced the Birlings as unashamedly upper class to what would have been an audience having just undergone rationing and times of deprivation.

Appropriate close analysis used as evidence for the point, demonstrating understanding of the writer's use of language

Good personal response, demonstrating understanding of wider issues at the time of writing

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Remains focused on the question with well-embedded quotations used to support the point

In addition, this introduction is striking in its contrast between the new and old generations. Sheila mocks "purple-faced old men" and implies a criticism of her father's social status by reminding him that he doesn't "know all about port". Eric, Sheila's brother, does not speak until the second page of the play, and his attitude and lack of manners are striking as they contrast with his social position and the situation of an engagement party. The audience are first properly introduced to him via the stage direction in which he "suddenly guffaws", interrupting the air of forced congeniality. There is the suggestion of distance between Eric and the rest of his family, as though he does not want to participate in the current charade. Eric's laugh could also imply that he knows what Gerald had actually been up to the previous summer. His final comment to Mr Birling of "Well, don't do any" implicitly criticises his speech making and the idea of Mr Birling showing off. Mrs Birling reproaches Sheila for using the colloquialism "squiffy" and puts an immediate stop to any squabbling between the siblings, as though she is used to such things but does not want anything to spoil the event. Mrs Birling's attitude towards marriage, and the fact that she is clearly in charge of the domestic sphere (as she issues the instructions to the maid), place her clearly in a traditional gender role, at odds with the newer generation, embodied by Sheila's warning to Gerald to "be careful" and her accusation that Eric is drunk.

Shows good understanding of the characters and their roles, demonstrating a strength of personal engagement with the passage and the play

The answer continues to closely analyse the passage as a starting point, bringing in wider development afterwards

In conclusion, Priestley creates an awkward atmosphere which is filled with tension, resentment and a sense of secrecy which will continue to build as the play progresses. The audience is left with the impression of a couple who desperately aspire to be seen as members of the elite, but who lack the elegance and breeding to do so; a future son-in-law who is polite and seems to say the right things, but is not necessarily all he seems, and two siblings who are at odds with the values they have been brought up with.

The conclusion neatly sums up what is striking about the introduction to the characters, without repeating points already made

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Unannotated model answer



Your notes

Priestley makes this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft by beginning the play **in medias res** at the Birling residence. Arthur Birling leads a toast to the upcoming marriage of his daughter, Sheila, and his future son-in-law, Gerald, and the audience learns that Gerald was occupied the previous summer at "the works". It is later revealed that this is a manufacturing company owned by his father and that it is a direct competitor to Birling and Company, Arthur's business. There appears to be an undercurrent of unease, revealed via Priestley's use of forced and stunted dialogue and stage directions.

Firstly, Priestley employs the use of tone, as Sheila urges Gerald with "mocking aggressiveness" to "object" to being treated like one of the family. She continues, with the stage directions indicating a half-serious, half-playful tone, reproaching Gerald that he "never came near me" all the previous summer. Gerald's excuse was that he was "awfully busy at the works" and she responds in the same tone "that's what you say". This foreshadows the revelation of Gerald's affair, and the "half serious, half playful" stage direction could reflect her naivety at the start of the play versus her maturity at the end. The audience is forewarned here that all might not be well, and the fact that Sheila is taking her first, tentative steps towards asserting her sense of self and rejecting a typical **patriarchal** marriage reflects the new, emerging role of women at the time Priestley wrote the play. Traditional patriarchal attitudes towards the role of women, especially in marriage, are reinforced by Mrs Birling when she tells Sheila that she will just have to get used to her husband not being around due to "work". This is ironic and perpetuates the idea that such **indiscretions** can be overlooked as men are busy with important matters of business, and that their wives should be grateful.

Furthermore, the introduction to the Birling family is striking in the absence of Gerald's parents at an engagement party. The use of the noble titles "Sir George" and "Lady Croft" suggest that there is a **disparity** in class between the Crofts and the Birlings, and that the marriage might not be as accepted by Gerald's parents if Sheila is seen to be of lower social standing. Mr Birling's sexist attitudes are reinforced by the hesitation in remembering Lady Croft's title, as indicated by the dash and the interjection "er". It is also striking that Mr Birling struggles to remember the name of one of his future son-in-law's parents, betraying his arrogance and ignorance. This is especially striking given that Mr Birling is clearly trying to impress Gerald, as he is keen to point out that the port he is serving is "exactly the same port your father gets". Mr Birling is clearly disappointed at the Croft family's absence, as it upsets his moment in the spotlight as the father of the bride, and the opportunity to show off his wealth **ostentatiously**. His attitude and symbols of status, such as the port, would have immediately introduced the Birlings as unashamedly upper class to what would have been an audience having just undergone rationing and times of **deprivation**.

In addition, this introduction is striking in its contrast between the new and old generations. Sheila mocks "purple-faced old men" and implies a criticism of her father's social status by reminding him that he doesn't "know all about port". Eric, Sheila's brother, does not speak until the second page of the play, and his attitude and lack of manners are striking as they contrast with his social position and the situation of an engagement party. The audience are first properly introduced to him via the stage direction in which he "suddenly **guffaws**", interrupting the air of forced **congeniality**. There is the suggestion of distance between Eric and the rest of his family, as though he does not want to participate



Your notes

in the current **charade**. Eric's laugh could also imply that he knows what Gerald had actually been up to the previous summer. His final comment to Mr Birling of "Well, don't do any" implicitly criticises his speech making and the idea of Mr Birling showing off. Mrs Birling reproaches Sheila for using the **colloquialism** "squiffy" and puts an immediate stop to any squabbling between the siblings, as though she is used to such things but does not want anything to spoil the event. Mrs Birling's attitude towards marriage, and the fact that she is clearly in charge of the domestic sphere (as she issues the instructions to the maid), place her clearly in a traditional gender role, at odds with the newer generation, embodied by Sheila's warning to Gerald to "be careful" and her accusation that Eric is drunk.

In conclusion, Priestley creates an awkward atmosphere that is filled with tension, resentment and a sense of secrecy which will continue to build as the play progresses. The audience is left with the impression of a couple who desperately aspire to be seen as members of the elite, but who lack the elegance and breeding to do so; a future son-in-law who is polite and seems to say the right things, but is not necessarily all he seems, and two siblings who are at odds with the values they have been brought up with.



Question B: What The Question Is Asking

Question B of Paper 2: Drama is the **essay question**. You must ensure you select the correct page of the exam paper that relates to the set text you have studied. The guide below will enable you to approach Question B with confidence. It is divided into:

- Overview
- Breaking down the question
- Top tips

Overview

You should answer **one** passage-based question on **one** set text, and **one** essay question on **another** set text. Question B will present you with a question that applies to the **whole** of the play. This Question is worth 25 marks and assesses all four Assessment Objectives. You have 45 minutes to answer this question.

In your response you are expected to:

- Demonstrate your knowledge of the play through reference to detail and the use of accurate, relevant quotations from the text
- Show that you understand the main ideas and explicit meanings in the play, as well as the implied or hidden meanings
- Analyse, in detail, the choices the writer has made in terms of their use of language, structure and form to **convey** impressions and ideas
- Shape your writing in such a way as to communicate your engagement with the play
- Demonstrate your understanding of the play and the question
- Be sensitive to imagery, sound and language to develop an informed personal response to the play

The suggested timings for Question B the essay question are:

10 minutes	Highlight the key words in the question Make a brief plan of the structure of your answer: ▪ Include which specific references to the play you are going to make that are relevant to the focus of the question
30 minutes	Follow your plan or annotations Write your response



It is important to read and check your work, rather than to try to write as much as you can in the time allowed. Answers that are shorter, but more focused and **concise**, are often more successful.

Breaking down the question

For this question, you will always be asked to write a response that explores how a writer conveys their meanings and messages in their play, focusing on a specific aspect or theme. The most common mistake students make in exams is not thoroughly understanding the question. By paying close attention to the question and understanding it thoroughly, you can enhance your exam performance significantly.

Below are a range of examples of Paper 2 Question B essay questions taken from past CIE IGCSE papers:

How does Hansberry **strikingly portray different hopes and ambitions** in the play?
Do **not** use the passage printed in Question 1 (a) in answering this question.

How does Miller's writing make you **feel about the way Danforth controls the witch trials**?

Explore **two moments** in the play where Sherriff's writing makes **you feel particularly sad**.
Do **not** use the passage printed in Question 3 (a) in answering this question.

To what extent does **Shakespeare's portrayal of Malvolio** make **you sympathise with him**?

In what ways does Miller **memorably convey the relationship between Joe Keller and his son, Chris**?

The focus of each question is indicated in bold

Some questions will explicitly tell you not to use the passage printed for the previous question

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Top tips

- Highlight the key words in the question:
 - The most successful answers maintain a clear focus on the key words in the question
 - Therefore, pay particular attention to what the question is asking you to do
- Quotations are intended to support your points, but should not be a point in themselves:
 - The strongest answers show a detailed knowledge of the text, by integrating precise and concise quotations and indirect textual references to support points
 - You need to be able to analyse and explain the relevance of the quotations you have chosen to your argument or to the question you are answering
- You should structure your response and your use of quotations in chronological order from the play:



- You should aim to select 6–7 relevant quotations that contain a range of language and/or structure devices that you can comment upon and analyse
- A high-level response will incorporate these quotations into the explanations of meaning
- Do not just state your ideas:
 - The most convincing responses sustain a critical engagement with the ways in which writers achieve their effects
 - Therefore, it is important that your explanation and analysis is supported with reasons
 - Use words such as “because”, “as” or “since” to offer reasons as to how the writer’s choices of language and structure achieve the particular effects that you mention
 - Make sure you link all of your ideas and reasons to the question
- Embed your quotations into your sentences:
 - Avoid unnecessary phrases such as “This is shown by the quote...” as this is just a waste of words
 - Instead, try: “Shakespeare makes this moment in the play so upsetting because Balthasar reveals that ‘her body sleeps in Capels’ monument’, which leads to the ultimate tragedy in the play”
- Ensure your introduction demonstrates that you have understood the task and that you have a thorough knowledge of the play:
 - You can do this by defining the focus of the question and summarising the main themes of the play
- Do not waste words on general topic sentences that do not make a specific point:
 - For example: “The passage is upsetting because of the language Shakespeare uses.”
 - This does not make any specific point that the examiner could reward with a mark
- Avoid being narrative:
 - You do not get any marks for just re-telling the play
- Make sure every paragraph answers the question:
 - Do not just write down everything you know about the play without any focus on the question
 - Make every sentence count!
- Ensure you include analysis of the use of structure and the form of the play, as well as dramatic techniques:
 - Writing just about the writer’s use of language can limit your marks
- In addition, avoid “feature-spotting”:
 - Listing techniques a writer has used without analysis will not get you marks



Your notes

- Your conclusion should be relevant and should summarise your personal response to the play and the task:
 - The strongest answers provide evidence of an informed and sensitive personal response to the text, which focuses directly on the key words of the question
 - It should not just repeat points you have already made
- Avoid lengthy discussion of the historical context of the writer and/or the time in which the play was written:
 - Context is not explicitly assessed in this IGCSE
 - Instead, your wider background knowledge should be used to inform your personal response to the play



Question B: How To Get Full Marks

The starting point for the analysis of any text is active reading. This means, as you read, annotating the text with your own comments and questions. Plays will often contain many layers of meaning, so it is important that you explore beyond any surface meanings to uncover the deeper ideas and themes. Some appreciation of the context in which a play was written can also help your understanding, but this should never be the main focus of your exploration.

It is tempting to jump straight in and start writing immediately. However, following this guide will ensure you answer the question in the way the examiners are looking for.

Below you will find sections on:

- What skills are required
- Steps for success
- Top tips

What skills are required

Each question on this exam paper assesses all four Assessment Objectives equally. This means it is important that you know what skills these Assessment Objectives require you to demonstrate in order to get the most marks.

- **AO1** is about demonstrating knowledge of the play's content with reference to specific sections of the text:
 - This objective is about working out what is going on in terms of content, structure and word choice
- **AO2** is about going beyond the surface meaning and story, to look for underlying ideas and attitudes – the writer's and your own:
 - This requires you to ask "why" the author has made the choices they have
 - Some elements of the writer's context can be used to inform your personal response, but only if relevant to the focus of the question
- **AO3** requires **critical engagement** and evaluation of how the text works:
 - "Meanings and effects" suggests that there is more than one meaning for a text, and the language, structure and form of the play contribute to those meanings
 - It does not mean just listing the literary techniques the writer has used
- **AO4** refers to the way you shape your writing in order to communicate your engagement with the text:
 - A personal response means that you may wish to make comparisons with similar experiences of your own, whether in real life or in your reading

- Contextual information should help reinforce your own interpretation, but not replace it
- Your own response is valid as long as it is supported by evidence

The following sections explore the skills you will need to demonstrate in more detail:

- Analysing drama
- Developing a personal response

Analysing drama

It is essential to remember that drama is written for an audience; plays and drama texts are intended for performance on a stage. This impacts how you read and consider a dramatic text, as you also need to consider how a play would appear to an audience.

Form and structure apply to drama as well as poetry and prose. The form is the type of writing the author has selected to tell their story and explore themes when presenting their work, while the structure is how the piece of drama unfolds. It is therefore important to consider what choices the writer has made in terms of form and structure, and whether they have conformed to, or subverted, the conventions of that particular form or elements of structure. The examples below are not exhaustive, and you are encouraged to research the dramatic form of your set texts.

Dramatic form	Definition	Examples
Farce	Comedy that entertains through situations that are highly exaggerated, extravagant, ridiculous or absurd	The Comedy of Errors by William Shakespeare
Satire	A way of criticising people or situations in a humorous way	Animal Farm by George Orwell
Melodrama	A play in which the characters display stronger emotions than real people	Still Life, Brief Encounter by Noel Coward
Domestic drama	A play that focuses on the realistic everyday lives of the middle or lower classes in a certain society	Death of a Salesman by Arthur Miller
Heroic drama	A play that involves epic stories of noble heroes and lavish, exotic settings	The Indian Queen by Robert Howard
Historical drama	Dramatic texts based on historical material	Henry V by William Shakespeare

Dramatic structure	Explanation
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Your notes



Your notes

Plot structure	A plot could be cyclical: ▪ This means there could be a recurrent theme or motif ▪ Or it could mean that the plot “circles back” to the beginning The writer might also use parallelism: ▪ This means the use of matching sentences, phrases or longer marks to balance ideas of equal importance You might also wish to consider the arrangements of scenes and/or acts, and why the writer has positioned them in the way that they have
Mood	Mood describes the feelings or attitudes of roles and/or characters It is the emotional impact intended by the writer
Juxtaposition	To place two things side by side to compare or contrast for effect: ▪ This might include the use of foil characters ▪ A foil is a character who contrasts with another character ▪ For example, Harry Potter and Voldemort are foils
Foreshadowing	This is a warning or a prediction of a future event in the play The writer might also employ dramatic irony, where the audience might be aware of what is coming, but the characters are not
In medias res	This is when the play starts in the middle of the action
Flashbacks	A scene in a play set in a time earlier than the main story: This device can be used to convey extra information about plot or character
Soliloquies/dialogue	A soliloquy is a speech that a character makes to themselves: ▪ It is a device through which a character’s inner thoughts can be made known to the audience Dialogue is a conversation between two or more characters in a play

You might also wish to consider the use of stage directions, setting, how conflicts are introduced and resolved (or not) and character development, and take particular note of how the play ends.

Some of the other things you need to consider when preparing your answer to the essay question include:



Your notes

- Take a whole-text approach:
 - In the essay question, this could involve commenting on structure: “at the start”/“this changes when”/“in contrast...”
- Always frame your essay with the author in mind:
 - As the examiners say: “writers use methods, including language and structure, to form and express their ideas – the choices the writer makes are conscious and deliberate”
 - Therefore, write that the author “highlights X”, “suggests Y”, “challenges Z”
 - Use the words “so” and “because” to push you to explain your own ideas further
- Zoom out to big ideas in your analysis:
 - Go from analysing language, or other writer’s choices, to the author’s overall intention or message
 - This should always link to the focus of the question

What not to do when analysing the author’s methods

- Do not just “spot techniques”:
 - Examiners dislike it when students use overly sophisticated terminology unnecessarily and without analysis
 - Knowing the names of sophisticated techniques will not gain you any more marks, especially if these techniques are only “spotted” and the author’s intentions for this language are not explained
 - Instead of technique spotting, focus your analysis on the **reasons** why the author is presenting the character or theme the way they are
- Do not just limit your analysis to a close reading of the author’s use of language:
 - You gain marks for explaining all of the author’s choices, not just their language
 - Instead, take a whole-text approach and think about the author’s decisions about:
 - Form
 - Structure
 - Characterisation
 - Setting
 - Staging and stage directions
- Never retell the story:
 - “Narrative” and “descriptive” answers get the lowest marks

- Move from **what** the author is presenting to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have



Your notes



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners like to see that students have an awareness of the form of a text, whether it's a novel, a play, a poem, etc. All texts on this paper are **plays**, and so it's important that you signal to the examiner that you know this. This is as simple as using the term "**audience**" instead of **reader**, and other play-specific terminology such as "**act**", "**scene**", "**on stage**" and even "**playwright**" instead of writer. It is also important to add that commenting on stage directions is as valuable as analysing any other writer's method. Indeed, it has the advantage of showing the examiner you are aware of the writer's intentions (the overall message he/she is trying to convey), because all stage directions are literally their intentions for what happens on stage.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

If you are studying a Shakespeare play as one of your set texts, then you might find our AQA revision notes on [How to Answer the Shakespeare Essay Question](#) helpful, as these go into detail about the different forms of Shakespearean drama and how to quote from Shakespearean plays.

Developing a personal response

A personal response is your opinion about the play, as relevant to the focus of the question. You are being asked to consider what the writer has tried to do and whether you think they have succeeded. However, it is important that your arguments are convincing, which means that they need to be supported with evidence. Your choice of evidence, whether that be direct quotation of language or references to the form and structure of a text, must be careful, accurate and effectively explained.

How to structure your response:

Start with an introduction that demonstrates that you understand the focus of the question and the play	You can do this by using the wording of the question to develop a thesis statement For example: "Shakespeare's portrayal of Malvolio in Twelfth Night makes me sympathise with him to an extent because his character develops in the play through his treatment at the hands of other characters."
Then, structure your response into paragraphs	Each paragraph should start with a topic sentence You should integrate direct quotation or specific reference to the text to prove your point Then comment on how this evidence proves your point



Your notes

	Each point you make must be directly relevant to the focus of the question
For the essay question	Start with a whole-text approach, discussing the structure and perspectives of the play as a whole, relevant to the focus of the question Then, zoom in on particular, specific parts of the play that are directly relevant to the focus of the question
Finish with a conclusion	Summarise your findings and your response to these findings Do not just repeat the points you have already made For example: "So overall, Shakespeare's portrayal of Malvolio presents the audience with both a victim and a comic target."

Steps for success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering this drama question effectively:

1. Grab your highlighter and **read the question first**:

- Read carefully and highlight the focus of the question

2. Do a brief plan of 4–5 points, linking to the quotations you are going to use

3. Start your answer using the wording of the question:

- This demonstrates to the examiner that you have understood both the question and the poem

4. Go into detail:

- Now you need to make as many points as possible, ranging throughout the play
- It is a good idea to make your points in chronological order, if possible
- Comment on and analyse language, form and structure
- Link your ideas to the theme and the focus of the question:
 - You should refer back to the keywords in the question throughout your answer
 - Use "because" or "as" to support your ideas with detailed reasons
- Explore the writer's intention and message

5. Sum up:

- Finish your answer with a "So overall..." statement
- Zoom back out to the big ideas in the text

- Your finishing statement should sum up what you have discovered, relevant to the focus of the question:
 - However, it should not just repeat the points you have already made



Top tips

- Avoid being too general or vague in your introduction:
 - Your introduction should address the Assessment Objectives in some way
- Avoid simply “re-telling” the narrative of the play
- Make sure every paragraph answers the question:
 - Do not just write everything you know about the text
- Avoid unnecessary words
- Re-read each of the paragraphs you have written before you write the next:
 - Check that each paragraph is clear and that it answers the question
- Ensure your selection of quotations is directly relevant to the focus of the question



Question B: Mark Scheme and Model Answer

The best way to improve any essay is to know how you are assessed, and what skills you are being assessed on. This page has been created to give you a sense of what examiners are looking for in a full-mark response. It contains:

- Overview
- Mark scheme
- Example task
- Model answer
- Unannotated model answer

Overview

Question B (the essay question) will ask you to explore, or analyse, how the writer of your chosen drama text has achieved meanings or ideas, as relevant to a particular theme. Your response must be supported with direct quotations or close reference to the whole of the play, as appropriate to the focus of the question.

Mark scheme

The mark scheme for any question in Literature in English is quite broad and can seem difficult to understand. This is because there is no “correct answer” for any essay: the exam board does not provide points that need to be included in any essay; instead, examiners use the mark scheme to place an answer into a level.

The questions in Paper 2 are equally weighted, and each question tests all four Assessment Objectives.

In simple terms, to achieve the highest marks (Band 8 = 23–25 marks), this means:

AO1	▪ Demonstrate your knowledge by incorporating well-selected references to the text skillfully and with flair in your answers ▪ This means using quotations and indirect references to the play to support your views or arguments
AO2	▪ Sustain a critical understanding of the text by showing individuality and insight ▪ This means showing that you understand the main ideas, settings, events, characters and other dramatic features, and that you appreciate the deeper meanings of the play



Your notes

AO3	- Respond sensitively and in considerable detail to the way the writer achieves her/his effects - This means that you are able to explore how writers use language, structure and form to convey impressions and ideas
AO4	- Sustain a personal and evaluative engagement with the task and text - This means that you are able to give a personal response to the question and text, and support your response with references to the text



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although there are four specific Assessment Objectives assessed in this task, it is not the case that a certain number of marks are awarded for any one objective. Instead, the examiners are looking for a well-constructed and coherent essay that seamlessly combines all of the skills covered by the Assessment Objectives.

Example task

The following task is an example of a CIE IGCSE Literature in English question, and it is about the play *A View from the Bridge* by Arthur Miller. It is typical of the style of a Paper 2 Question B essay question.

How does Miller powerfully convey to you the rules Eddie's community lives by?

Model Answer

Below you will find a full-mark model answer for this task. The commentary labelled in each section of the essay illustrates how and why it would be awarded full marks. Despite the fact it is an answer to the above question on *A View from the Bridge*, the commentary is relevant to any of the plays in the set text list, because it is modelling how to structure an answer incorporating the relevant Assessment Objectives.

This introduction focuses on the question and concisely summarises the main source of conflict in the play

Miller powerfully conveys the rules Eddie's community lives by in *A View from the Bridge* by exploring the central conflict for the characters in the play: the negotiation between the social laws of the Red Hook Sicilian-American society and the American laws they are bound to by the state.

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The answer goes on to demonstrate good knowledge of the play and its central themes and messages. This is supported by appropriate textual reference

Italy is the basis of the cultural traditions in Red Hook and unites the community in common social practices and religion. The community abides by Sicilian-American customs, protects illegal immigrants within their homes, values respect and family, is hard-working, values trust and wants revenge when a community member has been wronged. Initially, Eddie Carbone's core values are pride, duty, respect and honour, reminding us that "you can quicker get back a million dollars that was stolen than a word that you gave away". But it is his inability to successfully negotiate between Sicilian and American cultures that destroys him. He purposefully adheres to the state law that bans illegal immigrants, not out of a sense of duty towards American law, but for personal reasons as he feels threatened by Rodolpho's relationship with Catherine. He therefore betrays Rodolpho and Marco, and is consequently punished by the Red Hook community. Eddie chooses to turn against his community and abide by the state laws. As a result he loses the respect of his community and friends - the name and personal identity he values. Alfieri, in his role as a lawyer, warns Eddie that he "won't have a friend in the world", demonstrating how Eddie's actions will cause his downfall and the disrespect of his community. However, even though he betrays his community, he still seeks acceptance at the end of the play and spends his last moments fighting Marco to restore his good name.

Quotations are used to support points and are then analysed in terms of how they link to the focus of the question

The response ranges across the whole of the play, demonstrating knowledge and understanding

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In addition, Marco and Rodolpho break American law by entering the country illegally, but it is Marco in particular who has little respect for American law, instead abiding by the Sicilian practice of revenge against Eddie. Although what Eddie did was lawful, Marco embodies a more Italian sense of "justice" as he declares that "all the law is not in a book". He also adds that "in my country, he would be dead by now" demonstrating the contrast between the two different cultures and reflects the rules Eddie's community lives by.

Appropriate wider understanding of contextual factors informs the point being made, supported by relevant textual reference and an appropriate link back to the focus of the question

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Your notes

Furthermore, the title of the play symbolises the link between the two cultures referred to in the play: "the bridge" is the only physical connection between the land of opportunity and law, as represented by America, and the poorer Italian community which is governed more by social culture. The Italians of Red Hook are proud, working-class people who understand the struggle of poverty and do not take things for granted. They are proud to work at the docks and they do not think of this as an inferior role. In creating the role of Alfieri as a narrator, Miller draws on the tradition of the Greek tragic chorus. He is impartial and honest, commenting on the actions in the play. Trust is the first theme introduced; it is hard to gain in this community, as demonstrated when Alfieri passes by the longshoremen. Miller uses the stage direction that they "uneasily nod" to him, which shows the lack of trust they have of lawyers who they see as representing the rule of law. He begins the play by explaining the contrast between the law and Red Hook's perception of what is right, stating that in Sicily the law "has not been a friendly idea since the Greeks were beaten". Alfieri is portrayed as a well-educated man who follows American laws as well as taking Italian customs into consideration. As such, he is the symbolic link between the two cultures. He describes himself as powerless several times, emphasising his inability, even as a man of law, to stop the tragic events of the play. He is a teller of tales who cannot change what happens - just like Miller as the writer of the events.

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Demonstrates awareness of form and dramatic techniques

Again, this demonstrates awareness of the writer's craft and the play's form

In conclusion, community is a powerful context for the play, as it dictates specific norms and rules for the Carbone family that control the actions of the characters. All of the characters in the play are forced to reconcile between their adopted American culture and the Italian community culture, which provides conflict in the play. Miller therefore powerfully conveys the rules Eddie's community lives by, through showing how dramatically Eddie loses the respect of his community by abiding by American law, as opposed to the unwritten laws of Red Hook.

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The conclusion circles back to the focus of the question and neatly summarises the findings

Unannotated model answer



Miller powerfully conveys the rules Eddie's community lives by in *A View from the Bridge* by exploring the central conflict for the characters in the play: the negotiation between the social laws of the Red Hook Sicilian-American society and the American laws they are bound to by the state.

Italy is the basis of the cultural traditions in Red Hook and unites the community in common social practices and religion. The community abides by **Sicilian-American** customs, protects illegal immigrants within their homes, values respect and family, is hard-working, values trust and wants revenge when a community member has been wronged. Initially, Eddie Carbone's core values are pride, duty, respect and honour, reminding us that "you can quicker get back a million dollars that was stolen than a word that you gave away". But it is his inability to successfully negotiate between Sicilian and American cultures that destroys him. He purposefully **adheres** to the state law that bans illegal immigrants, not out of a sense of duty towards American law, but for personal reasons as he feels threatened by Rodolpho's relationship with Catherine. He therefore betrays Rodolpho and Marco, and is consequently punished by the Red Hook community. Eddie chooses to turn against his community and **abide** by the state laws. As a result he loses the respect of his community and friends – the name and personal identity he values. Alfieri, in his role as a lawyer, warns Eddie that he "won't have a friend in the world", demonstrating how Eddie's actions will cause his downfall and the disrespect of his community. However, even though he betrays his community, he still seeks acceptance at the end of the play and spends his last moments fighting Marco to restore his good name.

In addition, Marco and Rodolpho break American law by entering the country illegally, but it is Marco in particular who has little respect for American law, instead abiding by the Sicilian practice of revenge against Eddie. Although what Eddie did was lawful, Marco **embodies** a more Italian sense of "justice" as he declares that "all the law is not in a book". He also adds that "in my country, he would be dead by now", demonstrating the contrast between the two different cultures and reflecting the rules Eddie's community lives by.

Furthermore, the title of the play symbolises the link between the two cultures referred to in the play: "the bridge" is the only physical connection between the land of opportunity and law, as represented by America, and the poorer Italian community that is governed more by social culture. The Italians of Red Hook are proud, working-class people who understand the struggle of poverty and do not take things for granted. They are proud to work at the docks and they do not think of this as an inferior role. In creating the role of Alfieri as a narrator, Miller draws on the tradition of the **Greek tragic chorus**. He is impartial and honest, commenting on the actions in the play. Trust is the first theme introduced; it is hard to gain in this community, as demonstrated when Alfieri passes by the **longshoremen**. Miller uses the stage direction that they "uneasily nod" to him, which shows the lack of trust they have of lawyers who they see as representing the rule of law. He begins the play by explaining the contrast between the law and Red Hook's perception of what is right, stating that in Sicily the law "has not been a friendly idea since the Greeks were beaten". Alfieri is portrayed as a well-educated man who follows American laws as well as taking Italian customs into consideration. As such, he is the symbolic link between the two cultures. He describes himself as powerless several times, emphasising his inability, even as a man of law, to stop the tragic events of the play. He is a teller of tales who cannot change what happens – just like Miller as the writer of the events.

In conclusion, community is a powerful context for the play, as it dictates specific norms and rules for the Carbone family that control the actions of the characters. All of the characters in the play are forced to **reconcile** between their adopted American culture

and the Italian community culture, which provides conflict in the play. Miller therefore powerfully conveys the rules Eddie's community lives by, through showing how dramatically Eddie loses the respect of his community by abiding by American law, as opposed to the unwritten laws of Red Hook.



Your notes